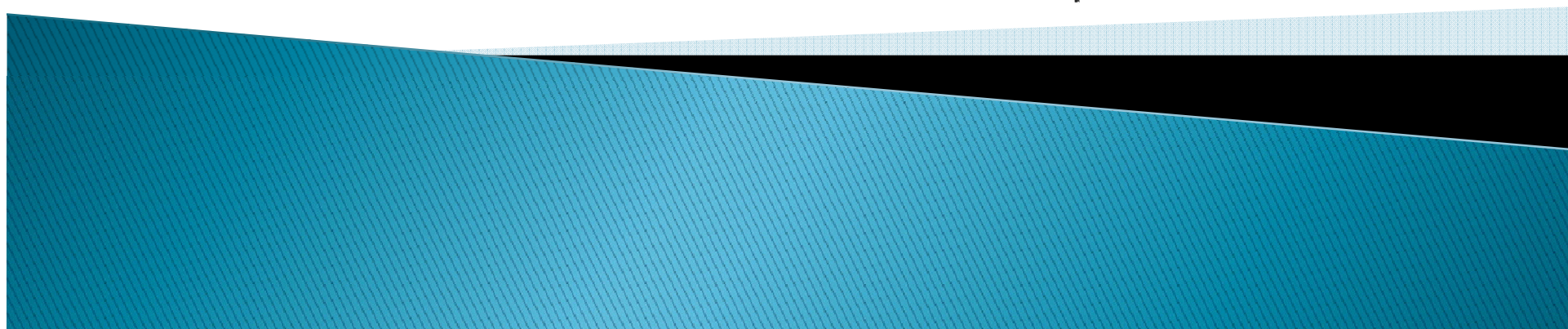


Gulf of Mexico Ecosystem Restoration Strategy: Communications & Stakeholder Engagement

Gulf Coast Ecosystem Restoration Task Force Staff

June 27, 2011



Components



1. Informing & Educating Interested Stakeholders

- ▶ State call-in lines
- ▶ User-friendly web site
- ▶ Email announcements to listserv
- ▶ Press releases

The screenshot shows the official website of the Gulf Coast Ecosystem Restoration Task Force, hosted by the EPA. The header includes the EPA logo and navigation links. The main content area features a large image of a sunset over a marsh, with a sidebar on the right containing links to members, meetings, and a meeting schedule. The sidebar also lists contact information and a government response section. The main content area includes a 'How to Get Involved' section with a list of questions and a 'Task Force Mobile Meeting Strategy Background Document' link. There is also a section for 'Upcoming Task Force Meeting and Listening Session' with details about the Galveston, TX meeting on June 27, 2011.

Components



2. Providing Opportunities for Involvement

- ▶ Public meetings
- ▶ Listening sessions
- ▶ Comments page on Task Force web site
- ▶ Task Force email in-box
- ▶ Federal Advisory Committees



Gathering Input from Stakeholders



We've been posing 3 questions:

1. How can we best keep you informed and involved in the process of developing the Strategy?
2. What, in your opinion, is the priority issue facing the Gulf regarding ecosystem restoration?
3. What do you believe are the impediments to addressing the priority issues.

Time Frame

- ▶ Starting Nov 8, 2010 listening sessions in Pensacola
- ▶ Continuing until May 6, 2011 release of the *Strategy Background Document*



Input Received

Over that period, we've received over 1,300 individual suggestions from over 1,000 individuals:

- ▶ Used in process of selecting our priority areas of concern



- ▶ Additional thoughts and suggestions noted
- ▶ Common themes emerged across stakeholder groups, and across states

Common Themes



Question 1: How can we best keep you informed and involved in the process of developing the Strategy?

ANS 1: Keep us informed/coordinated - 18% of all comments

Develop partnerships to ensure coordination between as many organizations and individuals as appropriate.

Ensure transparency/timeliness: Public needs to know about Task Force (structure, process, timeline, goals, activities).

Provide education and proactive outreach - make it personal!

Raise public awareness about the Gulf - should be as valued as the Grand Canyon.

Gain and keep credibility and the trust of the public.

ANS 2: Hear our voices - 8% of all comments

Get the widest participation to share data/information, create a vision, set goals, and implement Strategy.

There needs to be a citizen's advisory board to the Task Force.

Each set of answers represents 75% of the responses to this question received in round 1.

Common Themes



Question 2: What is the priority issue facing the Gulf regarding ecosystem restoration?

ANS 1: Our specific environmental issues - 25% of all comments

Clean up, proper disposal, and prevention of residual oil, dispersants and other toxic chemicals.

Think Big: we need a comprehensive approach at the watershed level.

Restore, enhance, and maintain the wetlands (or mitigate in kind) to protect the land.

We need preparation and prevention to make sure this catastrophe won't happen again.

Consider and encourage beneficial uses of dredged material.

Address subsidence/shoreline restoration: acquire land, preserve land, and work with land owners.

Very concerned about the hypoxic zone/nutrients and resulting loss of fish habitat.

Coastal communities must be adaptive and resilient.

Restore the gulf to pre-storm conditions: drinkable water, safe for recreation

Restore, protect, and promote living shorelines.

Address water quality issues - don't just focus on land issues.

Engage and monitor the effectiveness of adaptive management.

Recommend international coordination, e.g. Mexico, the Caribbean.

This set of answers represents 75% of the responses about specific environmental issues.

Common Themes

Question 2 continued



ANS 2: Understand/prioritize the impacts/science/solutions - 21% of all comments

What are the actual impacts and the sources/root issues? We can't restore what we don't understand.

How can we choose projects that will have the biggest positive impact (short and long term)?

Monitoring and data collection is critical to understand whether we are successful.

Understand how restoration interrelates with climate change, sea level rise, and other chronic stressors.

Use models: successful restoration needs predictive capabilities.

Want a science clearinghouse (database) describing methods & studies underway.

Need a dedicated agency with appropriate authority to oversee the big picture efforts.

ANS 3: Our economic concerns - 12% of all comments

Need to make sure allocated funding actually reaches the most impacted counties or parishes.

Work ecosystem restoration in tandem with local jobs: link monitoring and cleanup with economic development.

Evaluate and value ecosystem services: the multitude of benefits that are supplied by natural ecosystems.

Restore fisheries, support seafood. Seafood is unifying.

Support tourism by focusing on renewable industries.

Develop clean energy resources in the Gulf Coast like wind turbine farms, tidal pool generators, biofuels/bio-diesel.

Each set of answers represents 75% of the responses about the need for more information, and about economic concerns.

Common Themes



Question 3: What do you believe are the impediments to addressing the priority issues?

ANS: Obstacles we see going forward - 14% of all comments

Lack of (long-term) funding for research, monitoring, land acquisition, improved safety, habitat restoration.

Existing statutes, regulations, Agency policies and processes inhibiting progress.

Is this just another plan? or another Task Force? Too many plans, too many task forces, too little action.

Lacking accountability/liability from the polluter.

Once lost, always lost: the system had already had been damaged from decades of abuse.

Political conflict: getting reelected means more likely to fund economic projects than environmental ones.

Development and restoration not compatible.

This set of answers represents 75% of the responses to this question.

Comments under 4 Priority Areas



Of all the comments received up to May 6, half focused on one of the 4 priority areas

- Enhance Community Resilience
- Restore and Conserve Habitat
- Restore Water Quality
- Replenish and Protect Living Coastal and Marine Resources





Comments on 4 Priority Areas

- **Enhance Community Resilience**

“When you look to future,
consider the effects of climate
change and sea level rise.”
— Non-Governmental Organization

“Need a watershed
level plan.”
— Local Government

“The current planning
process has problems -
there is a disconnect
between organizations.”
— Business/Industry



Comments on 4 Priority Areas

- **Restore and Conserve Habitat**

“Oyster reefs provide huge ecosystem services value. You need to restore and protect these reefs.”

— Non-Governmental Organization

“Create partnerships between industries to provide better habitats.”

— Business/Industry

“Critical habitat needs to be monitored and modeled, including oyster reefs, submerged aquatic vegetation, salt marshes, and mangroves.”

— Academia



Comments on 4 Priority Areas

- **Restore Water Quality**

“You need to examine both storm water buffering capacity of wetlands and storm surge capacity.”
— Academia

“Fresh water in-flow is critical.”
— Non-Governmental Organization

“We have to get the farmer in Iowa to see the Gulf of Mexico from his kitchen window.”
— General Public



Comments on 4 Priority Areas

- **Replenish and Protect Living Coastal and Marine Resources**

“Consider land-based impediments, such as the dams being torn down in the west, to help fish populations recover.”

— General Public

“Our primary concern is the health of the fisheries.”
— Business/Industry

“Ensure that we have adequate research and information on the impacts to fish.”
— Local Government

Input Received through Advisory Committees



LGAC's recommendations were transmitted to EPA Administrator on April 21, 2011

Three primary suggestions:

- 1) Use a **bottom-up approach**
- 2) **Identify and resolve policy barriers** to restoration
- 3) Identify a stable **source of restoration funding**





Looking Ahead

- ▶ Awaiting the recommendations from the National Environmental Justice Advisory Council (NEJAC)
- ▶ Compiling comments received at listening sessions responding to the four priority areas described in the *Strategy Background Document*:
 - Mobile, Alabama May 6, 2011
 - Pensacola, Florida June 1, 2011
 - Galveston, Texas June 27, 2011
- ▶ Continuing to engage our stakeholders using the approaches mentioned today.





Questions?